JRD and Ratan were alike. They were kindred spirits. ‘I think he will be more like me,’ was JRD’s refrain. Irani, who knew both JRD and Ratan well, said that ‘there was a closer relationship, in my opinion, between Ratan and JRD than between Ratan and his father’. JRD further added: ‘[Ratan] is like me in so many ways, particularly in thought and honesty of purpose. I wanted a man who will lead by his intelligence, and he meets that criterion.’

JRD, who was known for his empathy and concern for the workers, had desired his successor to be a man of compassion who was acceptable to the employees of the group. He was a champion of employee welfare schemes. Responding to a statement by Russi Mody that he would make TISCO the best steel maker in the country, JRD had said: ‘Russi, it’s not important to be the best steel maker in the nation. It’s more important to do the best for the people who make it possible.’

Ratan was no less passionate about the welfare of workers. He had argued against the closing down of Empress Mills without providing for the livelihood of the staff who faced imminent retrenchment. He had on several instances even challenged the board of Tata Sons on the question of workers’ welfare in the 1980s. But it was done without publicity—as he always liked to do—away from the spotlight.

The Final Decision

By 1989, JRD was all but certain that Ratan was most suited to succeed him. He was not yet ready to go public with his decision, but it was inferable from his personal communications. Particularly revealing was the reply he sent to a New Year greeting from Ratan in 1989. In the letter marked ‘personal’, JRD wrote that he reposed complete confidence in Ratan and remarked: ‘I know that we generally think alike and I have faith in your judgment … I have never been more confident than I am today about your leadership of [the] Tatas and about your commanding role in their continued growth, success, […] I would like you to know that, so far as I am concerned the Firm’s leadership responsibilities are already in your hands. In fact, as 1988 faded, I decided that I would not, henceforth, make any decision or record any “directive” view on any matter of substance involving the Firm or the group as a whole without consulting you. I have